NAMING GAMES



If the Centre could grant Kerala's demand to be called 'Keralam', why deny West Bengal's proposal to call itself Bangla? This is what West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee** asked in Kolkata, taking note of how their request was gathering dust with the home ministry. The Centre says 'Bangla' may be confused with Bangladesh, but the CM is having none of it. While congratulating the "people of Keralam", Mamata also alleged a quiet BJP-CPI(M) understanding, reminding fellow Bengalis that New Delhi always keeps their home state waiting.

POLL-BOUND MENU



Fresh from a successful but stormy AI Impact Summit that saw one too many controversies, Union minister **Ashwini Vaishnaw** has swiftly returned to his other brief, the Rail Mantralaya. The occasion: the launch of the new 'Rail Tech' portal, aimed at drawing innovators to solve challenges faced by the railways. At the luncheon organised to mark the event, the menu featured Malayali cuisine, prompting predictable quips about the state's looming election. A relaxed Vaishnaw, though, deflected it all with a smile. True to habit, he also queued up at the buffet, serving himself and declining any assistance, a subtle swipe at the VIP culture he routinely criticises.

FREEBIE FURORE



Even as finance minister **Payyavula Keshav** says that Andhra Pradesh is "still not out of the woods" vis-à-vis the "financial mess" the previous YSRCP government left behind, state legislators have received a Rs 1 lakh gift coupon to buy smart gadgets. Independent MLC Borra Gopimurthy is the sole one to decline the gift, questioning the spending. It also remains unclear if the 11 YSRCP MLAs boycotting the House have accepted the money. One MLA said a decision on this would be based on "personal discretion".

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Avaneesh Mishra, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Avishek G. Dastidar and Prasad Nichenametla

HEALTH WATCH

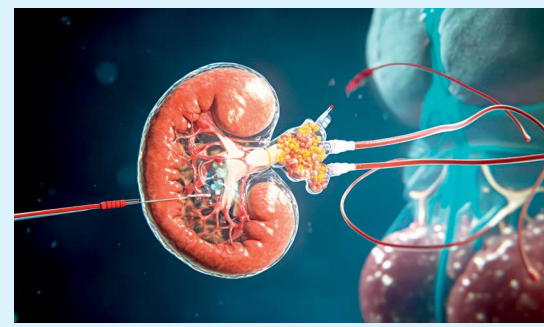
By **Sonali Acharjee**

TRANSPLANTS IN INDIA
MORE ORGANS SAVE LIVES

Organ donation services in India are undergoing a significant transformation, reflected in both scale and system-level improvements. Recent government data shows that organ transplants have increased nearly fourfold over the past decade, with close to 20,000 transplants performed in 2025 alone. At the same time, more than 480,000 citizens have registered for posthumous organ donation.

This growth is not accidental. It reflects sustained investments in transplant infrastructure, improved coordination between hospitals, better retrieval systems and the expansion of transplant units beyond metro cities. Advances in surgeries—such as robotic and minimally invasive techniques—have also improved outcomes, making transplants safer and more accessible.

States are strengthening support mechanisms as well. Kerala recently took steps to strengthen its organ transplant ecosystem. The state is compensating and formally supporting specialists involved in the time-sensitive process of transplantation. The aim is to improve coordination, reduce delays, and minimise organ wastage.



Together, these efforts signal a maturing organ donation framework. This is critical at a time when non-communicable diseases such as diabetes, hypertension and liver disease are rising, raising the demand for life-saving transplants across the country. The National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation (NOTTO) has a website where you can register to donate your organs. There's also a 24-hour helpline, call 1800-11-4700.